

Figure 5.23 *Lashkari Bazar, Palais aux Raquettes, ruins, exterior, north entrance. © Photograph Josephine Powell c. 1960. Harvard Fine Arts Library, Special Collections.*

of Racquets" close to Bust (Figure 5.23); and the distinctive interventions at the Ghazna palace (Figures 5.2–5.7), as well as at Lashkari Bazar's South Palace (Figures 5.14–5.22). All of these projects most likely would have been motivated by the intended utilization of these complexes – at the very least as "stages" for state ceremonial, if not also as residences.

Although there was no specific intervention attributable to the Shansabanis within the South Palace's Audience Hall I at Lashkari Bazar (Figures 5.24–5.28), we recall that abutting it immediately to the south was the exquisite Oratory F (Figure 5.20), which bore nearly unequivocal marks of Shansabani-period renovation. Hall I as the architecturally dominant part of the overall complex would have been extremely important for Mu'izz al-Din, the new ruler following in the footsteps of the Yamini–Ghaznavids. Considered by D. Schlumberger to be "without any possible doubt, the principal place of pageantry, the great audience chamber of the royal residence [i.e. the South Palace]," the Hall also initiated the kilometer-long, north–south central axis of the complex as a